

TEST PROCESS

In all, we looked at seven major, widely available, Linux distributions, that are also quite popular amongst users the world over. All the distributions were installed on an Intel Celeron 433 with 128 MB PC 100 SDRAM. The monitor was a Samsung 55V which can give a resolution of 1024x768, but only at 60 Hz. The hard drive was a Seagate 20 GB. A Creative 48x CD drive was used for installing the Linux distributions. An S3 Trio graphics card powered the display. The network card was a 10/100 Mbps D-Link 538 TX. The specific parameters that we looked at were

1. Installation features and ease of installation: This is an aspect that usually puts off a person from using Linux. We checked for an in-built disk partitioning tool and also features such as auto partitioning. Options to upgrade the installation and various modes of installation were also noted. We also checked for a boot manager and the various options offered.

2. Hardware Troubleshooting: We checked the hardware detection capabilities as well as options to configure the hardware to its optimum settings.

3. Applications: We specifically checked for the presence of office suites, imaging tools and viewers, movie players and other Internet accessing tools. Games and entertainment packages were also looked at, as also printing tools.

4. Integration: An important consideration was the integration of all the applications with the distribution's GUI.

5. Miscellaneous features: There were other standalone features that were present only with some distributions, for instance, system administration tools that allow you to create users and groups or File Managers.

We also looked at how the distribution helped in installing new software, the documentation provided with the distribution, the version of the kernel as also the desktop environment that was provided. The latest version of the Linux kernel that you can get for download right now is 2.4.6.

Finally, the various checks come down to four main points: Ease of Use, Integrity, Features and Value.

packages? True, the complete Linux distribution that you download from the Net is the real thing, but it comes minus the documentation, extra commercial packages and support, not to mention the fact that it would take forever to download them over a dial-up connection. These are goodies you do not usually get with distributions downloaded from the Net.

Easy as pie

The biggest hurdle for most desktop users in using Linux has been the installation. Most users get confused by terms such as fdisk, partitions, swap, etc, which are very basic and essential tools for installing a Linux distribution. Hence, it adds to the value of a Linux distribution if it has a simple installation process—especially for people who don't understand these complex terms—and still provides the option of going to the advanced mode and tweak it for better performance.

SuSE Linux was one of the most user-friendly Linux distributions we tested when it came to installation. The interface is designed such that you can access context-sensitive help from the menu on the left with ease. Most Linux distributions come with a whole lot of third-party tools and applica-

tions that are bundled along with the main distribution in different CDs; navigating and find out these installations can be quite tiresome. SuSE was really helpful on this count, in that it included most such packages in the main setup itself, so you don't need to go hunting for that small program on the third CD of that particular distribution.

Upgrading SuSE is very easy as online upgrading tools are available that automatically find out the latest versions of the packages installed on your machine and provide you with an option to upgrade them with a simple click.

Editing partitions can be confusing if you are a complete newbie to tools like fdisk. In both RedHat and SuSE, the installation procedure and style is more or less the same as their earlier versions wherein you can edit the partitions using a simple GUI with elaborate instructions on the left-hand side of the screen.

There's another option that lets the distribution take over the partition-creating process, and creates the optimal partitions all by itself. But this is recommended



Corel Linux: User friendly, but has an outdated KDE and kernel



More Info on the test process and the products tested, check out **Mindware**

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